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LA Federation Hanukkah, AJU Names COO, Combat Antisemitism Movement Honorees

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Jewish Federation Los Angeles brought together nearly 200 elected, civic, interfaith and community leaders for its 2025 Annual L.A. Leaders Hanukkah Celebration. Guided by this year's theme, "United in Light, Together We Shine," the LAFederation honored the community's shared resilience, strength and unity in the face of adversity. Through music, reflection and a renewed commitment to shared leadership, the program celebrated the light created when Jews and their allies stand together.

Attendees also gathered in remembrance, honoring the lives lost in the recent antisemitic attack in Sydney, Australia, while reflecting on a particularly challenging year for Angelenos — from the devastating wildfires and rising antisemitism and hate, to food insecurity and other crises impacting the most vulnerable. The celebration featured a communal menorah lighting and powerful stories honoring individuals and organizations who leaned in to support their neighbors in moments of need.

Elected officials that turned out included State Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino); LA County District Attorney Nathan Hochman; L.A. County Supervisors Hilda Solis, Holly Mitchell and Kathryn Barger; Beverly Hills Vice Mayor Craig Corman; and Beverly Hills Councilmember Mary Wells. Federation CEO Rabbi Noah Farkasand Senior Vice President of Community Engagement Joanna Mendelson also attended.

American Jewish University (AJU) has named Amy Latzer its new chief operating officer, a pivotal role that will help power AJU's mission to build a vibrant Jewish future — driving the operational excellence, innovation and community engagement that make the organization's work possible.

Latzer brings nearly two decades of executive leadership experience within complex, mission-driven organizations. She has a record of strengthening operations, modernizing systems, guiding teams through transformative growth and aligning institutions around bold strategic priorities —skills that will be instrumental as AJU builds a dynamic, future-focused platform for Jewish life, learning and leadership.

In her new position, Latzer will oversee all operational and administrative functions of AJU, including finance, human resources, facilities and auxiliary services, financial aid and oversight of AJU's Brandeis-Bardin Campus. She will partner with AJU President Jay Sanderson and senior leadership to advance strategic goals, elevate organizational systems and culture and support AJU's long-term vision.

"Amy is an extraordinary leader with the discipline, vision and heart to help AJU build a powerful future," Sanderson said. "Her ability to transform systems, strengthen teams and amplify mission will play a defining role as we reimagine what AJU can be for the next generation."

Before joining AJU, Latzer served for 19 years as the chief operating officer of 211 LA, one of the country's leading information and referral systems. During her tenure, she spearheaded major operational and technology modernizations, guided multimillion-dollar budgets, expanded community services and forged strategic partnerships.

Her connection to AJU's mission is personal: her daughter attended Camp Alonim, AJU's beloved summer camp, giving Latzer firsthand appreciation for the transformative impact of the Brandeis-Bardin Campus and the generations of community shaped there.

"I am honored to join AJU at such an energizing and transformational time," Latzer said. "This institution's commitment to innovation, education and community resonates deeply with me. I look forward to working with the exceptional teams across AJU to strengthen our operations and support the University's bold vision for the Jewish future."

Local civic leaders and community organizations were recognized at the 2025 Mayors Summit Against Antisemitism, hosted by the Combat Antisemitism Movement (CAM) in New Orleans from Dec. 2-4.

Among this year's honorees was Jewish American Heritage Month–Los Angeles (JAHM-LA), which, in partnership with the Jewish Historical Society of Southern California, received CAM's national Jewish Heritage Award for its innovative "Light the Path" initiative — a multi-year cultural and civic program leading up to the 2028 Olympic and Paralympic Games.

The award stems from CAM's national Jewish American Heritage Month contest which invites Americans of all backgrounds to celebrate the contributions of Jewish Americans to the nation's history, culture, and civic life.

Light the Path, co-founded by Mary Kohav and Adeena Bleich, is designed to illuminate the Jewish contributions that helped shape Los Angeles — from athletics and civic leadership to cultural innovation and urban planning.

"As we prepare for 2026 and our theme 'Jewish Champions,' we're committed to honoring the athletes, leaders, and everyday heroes whose courage and creativity have shaped our city," Bleich, also the co-founder of JAHM-LA, said.

Another LA-based organization honored at the CAM conference was Shonda Walkovitz and Judi Lieb's Challah and Soul, which was recognized for its work strengthening ties between Black and Jewish communities through food, storytelling and education. Their recent inaugural Soulful Seder, which blended Black and Jewish cuisines and traditions, was highlighted as an example of a program fostering unity, healing and shared celebration.

Attendees included Beverly Hills Mayor Sharona Nazarian, who emphasized the importance of collaboration across cities and institutions. "One of the most impactful parts of the summit was the opportunity to build partnerships that strengthen our collective efforts against hate, discrimination, and antisemitism," she said.

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